went. I don't know where it came from: the sound of that whistle was like an electric shock and I got this last burst of energy. I ran—sprinted—with my arms stretched out beside me, almost the length of the field and down to our fans. Most of the lads had just fallen on the floor: collapsed with exhaustion. Which was probably the best thing to do, but I couldn't help myself. The roar that broke out from the United supporters when the game finished was deafening and I felt like I was being shot out of a gun towards them. I don't know if I'll experience moments, or see celebrations, quite like those ever again.

We were out on the field for what seemed like hours afterwards, having a private party in the warm Spanish evening air: the lads who'd played and those who hadn't been able to, and the thousands of United fans who'd taken over the Nou Camp for the night. These were the supporters who'd welcomed me back to Old Trafford at the start of the season; who'd stuck by me after France 98, no matter what flak I was getting from anybody else. You could see on people's faces how much what had just happened meant to them and they could see how much the United players were enjoying being out there celebrating with them. It felt even more special for me: if it hadn't been for the supporters at that first Premiership game of 1998/99 at Old Trafford, I'm not sure I'd have been there at the Nou Camp on the season's final night. I'll never forget what they did for me. I know they'll never forget what we did for them in the dying minutes of the biggest game of them all.

It was pretty mad in the dressing room, too, once we finally found our way back there. Champagne was flying everywhere. Everybody seemed to be singing, screaming and laughing. We'd played a lot of soccer together, and now was the right time to go a bit crazy together. Eventually, people started getting dressed. We were looking forward to meeting up with our families. I remember just sitting in my place in the dressing room, watching it all go on around me, and trying to take in what we'd done. I looked over to the far corner and that huge trophy, the European Cup, was just standing there, on top of a bench, all on its own.

This is my chance. I found the United club photographer:

'Will you take some pictures of me holding this?

I walked back up the tunnel, past the little chapel and out onto the field again. Half the floodlights were still on. Half of them were off. There were strange shadows being cast across that huge stretch of turf, and the empty stands just sort of loomed in the darkness. You could still imagine an echo of